

BACKGROUND GUIDE

United Nations Security Council

Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (LAWS)

LANGUAGE

ENGLISH

FORMAT

INDIVIDUAL

DEPUTY UNDER-SECRETARIAT-GENERAL

UNITED NATIONS



MONUA XVI

UNIVERSIDAD DE LOS ANDES MODEL UNITED NATIONS

The Universidad de los Andes Model United Nations (MONUA) is an academic conference organized by students of Universidad de los Andes with the support of the Faculty of Social Sciences. Throughout more than fifteen editions, MONUA has established itself as a distinguished forum where secondary school and university students from Colombia and around the world come together to engage in diplomacy, debate, and the collaborative development of solutions to contemporary global challenges.

Through the representation of Member States, international organizations, institutions, and other relevant actors, participants research, negotiate, deliberate, and collaborate on political, social, economic, legal, and humanitarian issues. Beyond competition, MONUA is an educational experience designed to strengthen critical thinking, public speaking, leadership, empathy, and respect for diverse perspectives.

Inclusion and social responsibility remain fundamental pillars of the conference. Through initiatives such as Learning with MONUA, MONUA Fellowship, and other educational programs, MONUA seeks to make diplomacy, negotiation, and leadership opportunities accessible to children and young people from a wide variety of backgrounds.

Under the theme #EmpoweringEveryVoice, MONUA XVI reaffirms its commitment to creating spaces where every participant can contribute, learn, and advocate for their ideas through academic excellence, mutual respect, and international cooperation.

This edition will feature educational committees, United Nations bodies, specialized and legal committees, crisis cabinets, as well as media and interconnectivity committees. These Background Guides are intended to serve as the starting point for delegates' research, while the MONUA XVI Handbook outlines the conference's Rules of Procedure, code of conduct, and general policies.

MONUA XVI invites every participant to exchange ideas, embrace new perspectives, overcome challenges, and develop solutions that extend beyond the committee room. Each Background Guide has been carefully prepared to support delegates throughout their research process and to provide the foundation for informed, rigorous, and responsible participation.

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Welcome Letters

Board of Directors · Senior Staff · Committee Dais

Opening messages from the members of the Board of Directors, Senior Staff, and Committee Dais, whose leadership, commitment, and dedication make MONUA XVI possible.



Secretary-General

Salome Rodríguez Ballesteros

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Dear Participants of MONUA XVI,

If you are reading this letter, it means you are about to embark on an experience that I am certain will leave a lasting impact on you in many ways. Beyond debates, position papers, and resolutions, MONUA is a place to learn from others, discover new perspectives, and appreciate the value of diplomacy, dialogue, and cooperation.

My name is Salome Rodríguez Ballesteros, and it is my great honor to welcome you this year as the Secretary-General of MONUA XVI. I am currently pursuing a degree in Global Studies and Political Science, with concentrations in International Law and Economics. Like many of you, I found in Model United Nations a place where I learned that words, when used with respect and purpose, have the power to transform realities. I remember exactly what it feels like to arrive at your first conference with a mixture of excitement, uncertainty, and high expectations. I also remember the thrill of delivering my first speech, meeting extraordinary people, and realizing that these experiences are not about always being right, but about being willing to listen, learn, and grow. That is the experience I hope each of you will have at MONUA XVI.

Whether this is your very first conference or you have participated in many before, every committee is a new opportunity to challenge yourself, step outside your comfort zone, and discover abilities you may not yet know you possess. Do not hesitate to raise your placard, defend your ideas with respect, and build bridges even when differences arise. After all, that is what the United Nations stands for, and it is the spirit we strive to cultivate at MONUA. I want you to know that this edition has been prepared with great care by a team that truly believes in the transformative impact of these experiences. My greatest hope is that, when MONUA XVI comes to an end, you will leave with far more than an award or a certificate. I hope you leave with lasting friendships, meaningful lessons, and the confidence to continue using your voice wherever life takes you.

Thank you for placing your trust in us and for being part of this edition. I hope you enjoy every debate, every conversation, and every moment throughout the conference. I am confident that this experience will be only the beginning of many great things to come.

With my warmest regards,

Salome Rodríguez Ballesteros

Secretary-General

MONUA XVI – Universidad de Los Andes



Academic Secretary

Juliana Solano Sossa

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Dear delegates, sponsors, staff members, and all those whom it may concern,

My name is Juliana Solano, and I have the honor of serving as the Academic Secretary of MONUA XVI. I am currently in my eighth semester of Law and am pursuing a double degree in Business Administration at Universidad de los Andes. Throughout my journey in Model United Nations, I have found in these spaces not only a setting for rigorous academic training, but also a project that has allowed me to grow, challenge myself, and build a community of which I have felt deeply proud since the very first moment I became a part of it.

Today, I would like to warmly welcome you to this conference. We are truly delighted that you have decided to take on this challenge and become part of this edition. MONUA is not only a place to learn theory, debate, or refine argumentative skills—which are undoubtedly fundamental—but also a space to build experiences, create genuine connections, and discover the potential that each and every one of you possesses. My invitation is for you to approach this process not only with discipline, but also with intention and dedication. Allow yourselves to go beyond what is expected, to question, propose, and build. Take advantage of every debate, every intervention, and every interaction as an opportunity for growth. I hope this conference will be a space that challenges you academically, while also leaving a mark on you personally. May you find here not only a stage on which to excel, but also a place to share, make friends, and enjoy the process.

Welcome to MONUA XVI.

With my full commitment to accompany you throughout this process,

Juliana Solano Sossa
Academic Secretary
MONUA XVI



Director-General

Samir David Fernández Yunis

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Dear Participants, welcome to the sixteenth edition of MONUA.

My name is Samir David Fernández Yunis, and it is my pleasure to serve as the Director-General of MONUA XVI. I am currently in my seventh semester of Electronic Engineering at Universidad de los Andes, and for several years, Model United Nations has been a fundamental part of my academic and personal journey. From my first conferences in high school to my experience in the university MUN circuit, these experiences have challenged me, helped me grow, and allowed me to understand the world through a wide range of perspectives.

Throughout this journey, I have come to understand that MUN is a space where ideas, interests, and worldviews that often seem irreconcilable come together. It is precisely within that diversity that the most meaningful experiences emerge. To disagree is not to confront one another, but rather to engage with ideas, institutions, and perspectives that deserve to be questioned with rigor, integrity, and respect. That is the spirit we strive to foster at MONUA. For this edition, we set ourselves a clear objective: to deliver a conference that meets the standards of the most competitive delegations in Colombia and the region while preserving the international character that defines MONUA. The participation of delegations from across Latin America not only elevates the quality of debate but also transforms this conference into a true academic and cultural meeting point.

Our goal is to offer a conference that is ambitious, thoughtfully designed, and carefully executed in every academic and logistical aspect. Beyond committees and debates, MONUA is an experience. I hope these four days become not only an intellectual challenge, but also an opportunity to meet remarkable people, build lasting connections, and discover your own potential. I would like to express my sincere gratitude to everyone who has made this project possible: our academic team, the Board of Directors, our staff, and each one of you for placing your trust in this process. MONUA exists because of this collective commitment, and I am confident that this edition will meet your expectations and leave you with far more than outstanding results—it will leave you with unforgettable experiences and lasting connections.

With respect and sincere regards,

Samir David Fernández Yunis
Director-General
MONUA XVI

WELCOME LETTERS

BOARD OF DIRECTORS



Deputy Academic Secretary

Jose Alejandro Gutiérrez Cifuentes

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Dear Sponsors, Delegates, Observers, Staff Members, Parents, and Anyone Else Who Decided to Read This Letter,

Welcome to MONUA! A place to debate, to think, and—most importantly—to question.

My name is Jose Alejandro Gutiérrez Cifuentes, and for the sixteenth edition of MONUA, I am delighted to serve as the Deputy Academic Secretary of the conference.

I am currently pursuing a master's degree in Physics at Universidad de los Andes, and ever since I was young, I have loved movies, philosophy, and wonderfully terrible jokes. Somehow, all of those interests found a home in crisis committees, where I developed not only those passions but also the skills that have shaped the person I am today. Through MUN, I have learned to approach problems from multiple perspectives and to appreciate the value of interdisciplinary thinking.

Despite the many people who have tried to convince me that my academic background has little to do with Model United Nations, I have come to believe quite the opposite. When our goal is to pursue truth and strive to do things well, we cannot rely solely on the exact sciences. We also need the tools that dialogue, diplomacy, and debate provide. I hope this conference becomes, for you, what it has been for me: an opportunity to grow and, in our own small way, make the world a little better. I also hope that throughout this experience you find a space to collaborate with honesty, creativity, and an open mind, making the most of everything MONUA has to offer.

If this message resonates with even one person by the end of MONUA XVI, I will gladly quote two of my country's greatest icons with complete confidence: «There is something about Colombians: we never lose hope of doing better every single time,» and «We've lowered the ignorance levels just a tiny bit, professor,» by Jaime Garzón and La Cevichica, respectively.

Thank you, best of luck, and I'll see you at MONUA.

With warm regards,

Jose Alejandro Gutiérrez Cifuentes

Deputy Academic Secretary

MONUA XVI



Deputy Director-General

María José Penagos

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Dear delegates, sponsors, staff members, and everyone who is part of this story today: welcome to the sixteenth edition of MONUA!

My name is María José Penagos Granados, and I have the immense privilege of serving as the Deputy Secretary-General of MONUA XVI. I am currently pursuing a double major in Government and Public Affairs and Business Administration at Universidad de los Andes.

Ever since I was very young, Model United Nations has held a special place in my life. It taught me that ideas have the power to transform realities, that listening is just as important as speaking, and that true leadership is, above all, about creating opportunities for others to shine.

To me, MONUA is so much more than a conference. It is a place that inspires, challenges, and transforms. It is where people from different backgrounds and perspectives come together and discover that dialogue will always be more powerful than division, and that the most meaningful solutions emerge when we choose to build them together. I truly believe that change begins with those who dare to participate, to question, and to believe they can make a difference.

Thank you for placing your trust in this project and for choosing to be part of this edition. Behind every detail is a team that has worked with dedication, enthusiasm, and genuine care to create an unforgettable experience for all of you. I hope you will feel that commitment in every committee, every debate, and every moment you share throughout these days.

I encourage you to embrace MONUA with enthusiasm and generosity. Make the most of every speech, every hallway conversation, and every person you have the chance to meet. Allow yourselves to learn, to make mistakes, to grow, and to be surprised. Don't be afraid to raise your placard, stand up for your ideas, or listen openly to perspectives that challenge your own.

When MONUA XVI comes to an end, I hope you leave with far more than wonderful memories. I hope you take home lasting friendships, lessons that will stay with you for years to come, and the certainty that each of you has the power to create a positive impact. This conference is now yours—embrace it with curiosity, conviction, and an open heart.

With warmth, respect, and admiration,

María José Penagos Granados

Deputy Director-General MONUA XVI

WELCOME LETTERS

Deputy Under-Secretary-General



USG

UNITED NATIONS

Raúl Ruiz Aragón

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Hello everyone,

My name is Raúl Ruiz, a sixth-semester student of Systems Engineering and Government and Public Affairs at Universidad de los Andes, and together with Sebastián Delgado I will be your Assistant Secretary-General for the United Nations at MONUA this year. I hope we meet your expectations and that you enjoy the best Model United Nations in Colombia.

I have been involved in the world of Model United Nations for several years. Since high school, it has greatly interested me, and in university I have had the opportunity to be part of a delegation from my university and attend both national and international conferences. Therefore, I value academic rigor, debates with strong arguments, and not just a delegate who speaks loudly and uses the placard. However, this does not mean that debates have to be boring—I really enjoy when the committee is engaging and the debates are held to a high standard.

Setting aside the UN world, I really enjoy football (Real Madrid), Formula 1, and politics. So, having a coffee and talking about any of these topics can be the best plan I can think of.

I hope we have very interesting debates and that you enjoy MONUA. Beyond an award—which ends up in a drawer—be good people, meet others, and enjoy this experience which, at its core, is a simulation.

Sincerely,
Raúl Ruiz Aragón
United Nations USG
MONUA XVI

WELCOME LETTERS

Deputy Under-Secretary-General



USG

UNITED NATIONS

Sebastián Delgado Cabrera

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Greetings to everyone,

My name is Sebastián Delgado, and together with Raúl I have the honor of serving as the Assistant Secretary-General for the United Nations for this edition of the Model United Nations of Universidad de los Andes, MONUA XVI. I am a Mechanical Engineering student at the Universidad Nacional de Colombia, and although my field of study may seem notably distant from Model UN spaces, my interest in these events began in high school, where I came to believe that, regardless of one's career, communication and debate skills are indispensable for being a critical and constructive citizen in a country where dialogue is often one of the last resorts. For this reason, I am a strong advocate of traditional committees, where these characteristics are most fully developed.

Together with Raúl, we have designed a robust proposal characterized by academic rigor, where we aim for delegates to fully develop their capabilities in soft skills, research, and conflict resolution, while maintaining the procedural character that defines our ASG team. We hope that those who are part of it share the same passion we have for these spaces and stand out as well-rounded delegates, with a constant balance between substantive knowledge and discourse management, capable of building consensus, with a genuine intention to learn and a strong commitment to building a competitive and human committee.

From the SGA team, we are fully available to every individual who is part of the model to share a space that helps us grow as people, develop academically, and leave a mark on a circuit that, within its competitive mindset, has at times forgotten its main objective: to learn and to build connections with people from all corners of our country, and in this case, from across Latin America as a whole.

Sincerely,

Sebastián Delgado Cabrera

United Nations USG

MONUA XVI

WELCOME LETTERS

United Nations Security Council



Hello delegates,

My name is Francesca Feho, and I am a 23-year-old Political Science and Global Studies student at Universidad de los Andes. Throughout my academic journey, I have participated in multiple Model United Nations conferences, including Harvard's Model United Nations 2026, where I was honored to receive the award for Best Delegate and where Universidad de los Andes achieved historic results.

This year, I will have the pleasure of serving as your DAIS for MONUA's Security Council. Hence, I expect a committee built around substantive debate, creative solutions, and a strong understanding of the complexity of the issues we will address. Excellence in committee requires both diplomatic creativity and professionalism, and I will expect delegates to bring their best preparation and strategic thinking.

Outside MUN, I work as a Financial Consultant at Mastercard, where I have gained firsthand experience in a highly competitive, data-driven environment. Working with data and strategic decision-making has shown me the importance of creating solutions that are not only innovative but also technically sound and realistic. Therefore, in regards to your proposals, I will be looking for depth, feasibility, and a clear understanding of the challenges behind your solutions.

Personally, I value creativity, humor, and genuine connections. While this committee will require seriousness and dedication, I also want you to enjoy the experience. The best debates are not always the most predictable ones.

Remember: nothing is personal, and nothing is too serious to experiment with. I do not want rehearsed speeches or robotic diplomacy, I want authentic debate, strategic disagreements, and delegates who are willing to take risks. Challenge each other, surprise each other, and most importantly, show me who you are from your very first speech (the key to anything in life is being yourself).

I look forward to seeing your ideas, your ambition, and your ability to navigate complex discussions.

Sincerely,

Francesca Feho

Chair of the United Nations Security Council

WELCOME LETTERS

United Nations Security Council



Chair

Mariana Amaya Facundo

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Hey delegates!!!

My name is Mariana Amaya Facundo. I'm a 22 year old law and marketing student at Universidad del Rosario, and I'm thrilled to be your DAIS for this year's UNSC at MONUA! My journey with MUN goes far back (more than I'd like to admit!), and I've had the opportunity to represent my university at Harvard National Model United Nations (HNMUN) in Boston.

In my personal life, I adore fashion (I'm always looking at runways, reading Vogue, or scrolling through Pinterest). I'm also a huge fan of music, especially Harry Styles and Latin Mafia, but I'm currently obsessed with Olivia Dean, Role Model, and Lauryn Hill. My all-time favorite movie is Breakfast at Tiffany's. I also love baking and going out with my friends.

Throughout my life, I've learned that the most important thing is to stay true to yourself, so I hope each one of you shows your most authentic self. I'm eager to see strong academic and creative proposals, and of course, lots of energy.

That being said, I hope to see you all very soon. If you have any doubts, do not hesitate to contact me.

Sincerely,
Mariana Amaya Facundo
Chair of the United Nations Security Council

WELCOME LETTERS

United Nations Security Council



Chair

Sara Velilla

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Hello!

My name is Sara Velilla. I'm currently majoring in International Relations and minoring in Anthropology in Universidad del Rosario. I have participated in MUN models since the early days, back in high school, but I keep learning every time I enter a committee. That is why I'm thrilled to accompany you in this Security Council. I believe it might be my favorite UN organ! I find all topics treated by this committee interesting because they allow me to drift away from my humanities minor. Instead, the UNSC allows me to explore conflict and security studies which is my favorite branch of International Relations.

When I'm not studying, I enjoy lots of other things. I wish I had more than twenty four hours! I'm an outdoors girl. I love to play football, cycle, hike and this semester I'm planning on starting bouldering. I love hanging out with friends, having a laugh or debate about the most controversial stuff out there. But once the clock hits 7pm, I'd be heading to my apartment to chill on my own: listen to some house, play guitar, watch a movie and prepare for the next day. I like to strike a balance, in summary.

Back to the committee, I have always believed that the ideal delegate is a genuine diplomat. This means, remaining loyal to your objectives and beliefs, and working towards them, but without ever disregarding the presence and humanity of your fellow delegates. At the same time, a diplomat is an interesting person: a person that sparks debates, that dares to try new things. So I'd say: become a diplomat for this committee! And that way, you shall enjoy and learn.

My best wishes, Sara.

Chair of the United Nations Security Council

Section

Preamble

Regarding Electronic Devices: Within the United Nations SGA, the use of electronic devices such as laptops, tablets, or iPads is permitted. Delegates may use these devices to gather information, edit documents in real time, and use MONUA Connect (MONUA's platform for messaging and other activities) during session days. The misuse of these devices, such as social media, video games, or other distractions, is strictly prohibited during committee meetings and will result in a warning to the delegate. Committee dais or other members of the academic staff will monitor the proper use of each device.

The use of cell phones during session times is strictly prohibited. If a delegate wishes to contact their sponsor, they must request permission from the chairperson via floor message, and the chairperson will arrange the call. In case of a personal situation, the chairperson may be notified, and an exception will be made.

On the Use of Artificial Intelligence: For the United Nations Deputy Under-Secretariat-General, the use of artificial intelligence is limited to the generation of images and videos. If spell-checking is performed using artificial intelligence, it must be reported to the dais before editing so that the initial version can be reviewed. The use of any artificial intelligence for generating text or speeches, or for research (during any session), is strictly prohibited and will result in a reprimand if detected. We believe that the responsible use of AI will enrich the debate and energize the committee; however, the preparation and soft skills of the delegates are fundamental pillars for the committee's academic development, and therefore we expect them not to rely on AI to demonstrate these skills. In particular, the research and proposals generated by artificial intelligence are evident.

Section

Key Words

- **Lethal Autonomous Weapon Systems (LAWS):** As of now, there is no international consensus on the definition of LAWS. Nonetheless, most documents categorize them as weapon systems capable of identifying, selecting and neutralizing targets without human intervention (International Committee of the Red Cross, 2022).
- **Semi-autonomous Weapon Systems:** The system is programmed to attack targets previously selected by a human operator (Center for Strategic and International Studies, s. f.).
- **Explainable AI:** "Criteria used to describe an AI model, its expected impact and potential biases. It helps characterize model accuracy, fairness, transparency and outcomes in AI-powered decision making" (IBM, s. f.).
- **Loitering munitions:** "Loitering munitions are aerial weapons equipped with some form of built-in warhead. These weapons are designed to loiter around a target area until a target is located, then attack the target by crashing into it. Loitering munitions are also referred to as a suicide drone, kamikaze drone, or exploding drone" (Beebe, 2025).
- **In the loop:** Human involvement within the process is required for the process of identification, selection and neutralization to take place (Steelberg, 2019).
- **On the loop:** Human involvement within the LAWS becomes a check to make sure that the processes are running normally and to verify accuracy (Steelberg, 2019).
- **Out of the loop:** Human involvement is not required. LAWS are self-sufficient enough to execute the operations independently (Steelberg, 2019).
- **STM:** Security and Trust Management refers to the creation, implementation, and supervision of encryption techniques, security policies, and privacy protections in technological systems. To guarantee dependability, integrity, and safe interactions, it also entails building and preserving trust in dispersed environments, such as wireless devices and IoT networks.

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- **UCAV:** A military aircraft designed specifically to drop weapons like bombs or missiles during tactical operations is known as an Unmanned Combat Aerial Vehicle (UCAV). These aircraft fly without a human pilot on board. These aircraft are used for intelligence, surveillance, and combat missions and can be fully autonomous or remotely piloted. They are not the same as unarmed drones, which are usually only used for reconnaissance.
 - **ISR:** Known as Intelligence, Surveillance, and Reconnaissance is the coordinated and integrated gathering, evaluation, and dissemination of trustworthy information to support military operations, it uses in the air, land, sea, and space to collect information that enhances situational awareness, spots possible threats, and guides tactical and strategic decision-making.
 - **EW:** Electronic Warfare refers to military operations that use the electromagnetic spectrum including radio waves, radar, and infrared, to seize control of that area. It includes measures to protect and preserve dependable access for friendly forces while interfering with and weakening enemy radar and communications systems.
 - **FPV:** First Person View refers to operating unmanned aerial vehicles or drones using goggles or screen to see real time footage from on board cameras so it provides an immersive operator-centric perspective, allowing for highly agile, precise surveillance, navigating confined spaces, and rapid reconnaissance.

Section

Introduction

United Nations Security Council

Welcome delegates!

You are now seated in the most powerful and consequential body of the international system. The Security Council is not a space for theoretical debates, abstract morality, or comfortable consensus. It is the arena where sovereignty collides with survival, where law meets power, and where decisions are measured not in words, but lives, borders, and global stability.

Unlike other committees, the Security Council does not ask what should ideally happen, but what can realistically be done under conditions of urgency, uncertainty, and unequal power. Here, every clause carries weight, every veto carries consequences, and every moment of indecision has a cost.

As delegates, you will be expected to act not as advocates of personal ideals, but as representatives of states with strategic interests, historical grievances, security doctrines, and red lines. Cooperation is necessary, but never guaranteed. Compromise is valuable, but never free.

The world you inherit in this committee is unstable, multipolar, and increasingly fragmented. Conflicts are no longer isolated; they spill across regions, supply chains, cyberspace, and civilian life. The legitimacy of international institutions is questioned, but their absence would be far more dangerous.

Your task is not to create a perfect world. Your task is to prevent it from collapsing further.

Welcome to the Security Council, where neutrality is not an option.

Section

United Nations Security Council

■ History of the Committee

In 1939, the outbreak of World War II exposed the inability of the League of Nations, the predecessor of the United Nations, to prevent major conflicts and maintain international peace. In response to these shortcomings, U.S. President Franklin D. Roosevelt proposed “Four Policemen” (China, the USSR, UK and the U.S) as guarantors of a new world order. This concept later on evolved into the Security Council included in the United Nations Charter, formalized in 1945.

The Council has always been tasked with the maintenance of international peace and security. The structure originally consisted of the Four Policemen, France and other six non-permanent members. As decolonization led to the emergence of numerous newly independent states, the United Nations expanded the number of non-permanent seats from six to ten, creating the fifteen member structure that exists today.

It is important to highlight that a transition took place in 1971 when the Republic of China transitioned to the People’s Republic of China. Similar to 1991, when the Russian Federation was recognized as the legal successor to the Soviet Union. The Council has recently faced backlash by critics who doubt its efficacy for maintenance of peace after the 2022 invasion of Ukraine by Russia, a permanent member and frequent holder of the presidency of the Council.

■ Binding power

The UN Security Council (UNSC) is the only organ of the United Nations whose decisions can be legally binding on States, in other words they are enforceable on States. This authority derives from the UN Charter, through which Member States have agreed to comply with certain decisions adopted by the Council. This binding power, however, depends on the legal basis of the resolution itself and it is constrained by the UN Charter and general international law.

Under Article 25 of the UN Charter, member states are to “accept and carry out” the decisions of the UNSC; when combined with Article 103 of the same Charter, these decisions prevail over conflicting treaty obligations when properly adopted. When acting under Chapter VII of the Charter, the council can determine “threats to the peace, breaches of the peace, or acts of

aggression” and impose measures including sanctions and the use of force, which are clearly binding on all UN Member States, and in practice, often affect non members as well.

Some authors even describe the Security Council as a “world legislator” since some resolutions like 1373 (counter-terrorism) and 1540 (WMD non proliferation) settled general, ongoing obligations for States. Others argue this goes beyond the powers of the Charter and of the Council.

■ Members

The Security Council consists of fifteen members: the five permanent members and ten non-permanent members that enjoy a period of two years in the Council and are elected by the General Assembly. The current composition of the Council is:

(Permanent)

- People’s Republic of China
- Republic of France
- United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland
- Russian Federation
- United States of America

(2025-2026 term)

- Islamic Republic of Pakistan
- Republic of Panama
- Federal Republic of Somalia
- Hellenic Republic of Greece
- Kingdom of Denmark

(2026-2027 term)

- Republic of Colombia
- Kingdom of Bahrain
- Democratic Republic of the Congo
- Republic of Latvia
- Republic of Liberia

■ Veto power

The veto power of the five permanent members (P5) is central to global security governance but is widely criticized for enabling paralysis and inequality. Recent conflicts (Syria, Ukraine, Gaza ...) have intensified scrutiny and calls for reform.

The veto emerged from the post 1945 “great power unanimity” bargain; the UN could only exist if the major wartime powers retained a blocking right on substantive decisions. It is embedded

implicitly in Article 27 of the Charter and lets any P5 members nullify a draft resolution regardless of majority support.

The UNSC veto was designed to keep major powers cooperating, but contemporary research shows it often obstructs timely, equitable responses to crises and mass atrocities, eroding UNSC legitimacy.

■ Characteristics of the Committee

- **Subsidiary organs:** The Council has a network of subsidiary organs that specialize in specific global issues. These issues range from committees focused on counter-terrorism to nuclear weapons, and the oversight of international tribunals.
- **Panels of experts and monitoring groups:** Temporary and investigative subsidiary organs of the Council that especially oversee the arms embargoes (explained in the following section) imposed by the Council. The mandate of the panels and groups must be renewed annually. This is the main fact-finding tool for the Council to make decisions.
- **Strategic partnerships:** Regional organizations such as NATO have worked closely with the Security Council in the execution of missions, such as the Libya invasion of 2011. Important to highlight is the role of the African Union in the Darfur Crisis, acting on behalf of the Council's orders.

■ Things the UNSC can do

Under the UN Charter, the UNSC has primary responsibility for international peace and security and can take both non-force and force measures, mainly under Chapters VI and VII.

On one hand, Chapter VI defines the peaceful means as non-binding tools, like investigations, calling for ceasefires, mediation, and recommendations for peaceful settlement of disputes. On the other hand, Chapter VII defines binding enforcement, once it finds a "threat to the peace, breach of the peace, or act of aggression" (Art. 39), it can adopt binding measures on all UN members.

The Council has also authorized various peacekeeping, peacemaking, and peace enforcement operations. While peace enforcement missions are typically linked to Chapter VII authority, peacekeeping operations are not explicitly provided for in the UN Charter and have developed through practice. Many peacekeeping missions operate with the consent of the host state, a mandate from the Security Council, and in some cases, authority to use force under Chapter VII for specific purposes such as civilian protection.

Additionally, under Article 41 the UNSC can adopt measures not involving armed force. Here's a list of a few:

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- Economic and financial sanctions: To coerce policy change and punish violations. Some of these sanctions include trade embargoes, asset freezes, and financial restrictions.
 - Arms & commodity embargoes: To limit conflict capacity and deter proliferation. These embargoes include arms bans and export limits
 - Travel & mobility sanctions: To isolate leaders and prevent operations. These include travel bansaviation restrictions.
 - Diplomatic measures: To signal condemnation and increase pressure. Some include severance of diplomatic relations and limiting missions.
 - Targeted or “smart” sanctions: To reduce humanitarian harm vs. broad embargoes. These include listing specific individuals and/or entities, mainly for terrorism, International Humanitarian Law, or nuclear issues.
 - Subsidiary bodies sanctions: To oversee implementation and compliance. Including sanctions committees and expert monitoring groups.

Section

Statement of the Problem

When Machines Decide Who Lives and Who Dies

The international community now confronts a transformation in warfare that challenges the very foundations upon which the law of armed conflict was constructed. Autonomous Weapon Systems (AWS) are generally understood as weapons that, once activated, can select and engage targets without further human intervention (United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs, 2019). While automation has long been present in military technologies, the contemporary shift lies in the increasing capacity of systems powered by artificial intelligence to perform functions that were once exclusively human: identifying targets, assessing threat levels, and executing lethal force.

■ Dilemma within International Law

The problem before the Security Council is not merely technological. It is fundamentally normative. International Humanitarian Law (IHL) rests upon human judgment. The principles of distinction and proportionality require context-sensitive evaluation of civilian presence, military necessity, and anticipated collateral damage (International Committee of the Red Cross, 1949). Yet the delegation of lethal decisions to algorithms introduces profound uncertainty regarding whether such systems can meaningfully interpret complex human behavior or rapidly shift battlefield conditions. The International Committee of the Red Cross (International Committee of the Red Cross, 2021) has repeatedly warned that removing meaningful human control over the use of force risks undermining compliance with these core legal obligations.

There are inherent contextual biases as well. Machines lack the ability to perform contextual-based evaluations of human behavior or gestures. International Humanitarian Law requires context-specific judgments regarding the principle of distinction and the rule of proportionality. Because machines lack human intuition, they might struggle when distinguishing between a lawful military objective and a civilian object, or to recognize a combatant's genuine intent to surrender. This could result in failure when upholding humanitarian protections.

■ Enforcement Mechanisms and Accountability

Equally troubling is the question of accountability. If an autonomous system commits a violation of IHL, responsibility becomes diffuse. Traditional legal doctrines assume a clear chain of command linking individual decision makers to battlefield outcomes. However, AWS blurs this line between programmer, manufacturer, commander, and state. The architecture of autonomy risks creating what scholars describe as an “accountability gap” in which harm occurs without identifiable human agency capable of bearing legal responsibility and individual criminal liability; this represents not a minor adjustment, but a structural disruption.

Beyond legal compliance lies the strategic dimension. The increasing speed of algorithmic decision-making may compress the temporal space in which political leaders can exercise restraint. The integration of AI into military systems risks accelerating escalation dynamics, particularly among technologically advanced powers engaged in strategic rivalry. The Secretary General of the United Nations has characterized fully autonomous weapons as “politically unacceptable and morally repugnant” (Guterres, 2018), yet research, development, and limited deployment of increasingly autonomous capabilities continue. The international system thus faces a widening gap between normative concern and regulatory reality.

■ Ethical and Moral Considerations

The debate also focuses on the preservation of human dignity and the moral implications of delegating life-and-death decisions to Artificial Intelligence or other types of software. A primary concern is that allowing LAWS to select targets represents a form of objectification that denies the victim’s humanity. As stated in the 1899 Hague Convention II, in cases not covered by specific treaties, civilians and combatants still fall under the protection of international law. This is known as the Martens Clause, and is often cited in LAWS debates (International Committee of the Red Cross, 2018).

There are several stances on the topic. Consequentialist approaches argue that LAWS might eventually reduce civilian casualties through accuracy and precision, but opponents to this perspective state that delegating the decision, not only the task, to neutralize or not a target erodes human agency and promotes disregard to human dignity. In other words, the burden of taking the life of a human being cannot be passed on to a machine.

Section

History and Evolution of the Debate

From Remote Warfare to Algorithmic Agency

The debate over autonomous weapon systems did not emerge from speculation; it arose from tangible technological acceleration and growing unease within both military and humanitarian communities. The modern conversation can be traced to the early 2010s, when rapid advances in artificial intelligence, particularly machine learning and computer vision, began to make fully autonomous targeting technically plausible rather than hypothetical. Around the same time, military powers including the United States, China, Israel, Russia, and South Korea were investing heavily in AI-enabled defense technologies, integrating algorithmic systems into surveillance, missile defense, drone, and drone platforms.

In 2012, the United States Department of Defense issued Directive 3000.09, establishing internal guidelines for the development and deployment of autonomous and semi-autonomous weapon systems (U.S. Department of Defense, 2012; 2023). While the directive required appropriate levels of human judgment over the use of force, it did not prohibit the development of increasingly autonomous capabilities. Other technologically advanced states followed similar paths. Israel expanded its use of loitering munitions capable of autonomous target engagement functions, while South Korea deployed the SGR-A1 sentry system along the Demilitarized Zone, a platform often cited in early debates due to its potential autonomous firing capabilities, though reportedly kept under human supervision.

The issue entered formal multilateral discussion in 2013 under the framework of the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW), when states agreed to explore the implications of what were then referred to as “lethal autonomous weapons systems” (LAWS). Beginning in 2014, the CCW convened a series of informal Meetings of Experts to examine the legal, ethical, technical, and military dimensions of autonomy in weapons systems. These discussions provided the foundation for a more structured diplomatic process. In 2016, CCW High Contracting Parties agreed to establish a Group of Governmental Experts (GGE) on LAWS, which held its first formal session in 2017. Early discussions focused on definitions, technological capabilities, and the applicability of existing International Humanitarian Law. As negotiations progressed,

however, significant political divisions emerged regarding the need for new international regulations and the appropriate level of human control over the use of force.

A coalition of states, among them Austria, Brazil, Chile, Costa Rica, Mexico, and Pakistan, began advocating for a pre-emptive, legally binding prohibition on fully autonomous weapons, arguing that delegating life-and-death decisions to machines would violate the spirit, if not the letter, of International Humanitarian Law. Civil society organizations, most prominently the Campaign to Stop Killer Robots, launched in 2013, mobilized global advocacy efforts and framed the issue in moral and humanitarian terms (Campaign to Stop Killer Robots, 2013).

In contrast, major military powers adopted more cautious or resistant positions. The United States maintained that existing International Humanitarian Law was sufficient to regulate emerging technologies and emphasized the importance of maintaining flexibility for national defense innovation. Russia repeatedly expressed skepticism toward negotiating a new legally binding instrument, arguing that premature regulation could hinder technological development and strategic balance. China's position evolved over time; while expressing support in principle for prohibiting fully autonomous lethal weapons, it simultaneously continued research and investment in AI-enabled military systems, leading to concerns about the gap between declaratory policy and operational practice.

The consensus-based structure of the CCW significantly shaped the trajectory of negotiations. Because decisions require unanimity, even a small number of dissenting states could prevent movement toward a binding treaty. By the late 2010s, discussions had shifted from whether autonomy posed legal and ethical challenges to whether the existing law was sufficient to codify restrictions. Despite repeated affirmations that International Humanitarian Law applies to autonomous systems, no new legally binding instrument has emerged.

Concrete battlefield developments intensified the debate. In 2021, a report by the United Nations Panel of Experts on Libya suggested that a Turkish-manufactured Kargu-2 loitering munition may have operated in autonomous mode during hostilities, potentially engaging targets without direct human control (United Nations Panel of Experts on Libya, 2021). Although the degree of autonomy remains debated, the incident marked a turning point: the conversation was no longer theoretical. Autonomous engagement was no longer a scenario confined to research laboratories.

Meanwhile, technological competition among major powers accelerated. The United States incorporated AI-enabled decision-support tools into its Joint All-Domain Command and Control (JADC2) initiatives. China advanced its doctrine of "intelligentized warfare," explicitly integrating artificial intelligence into military modernization strategies. Russia tested autonomous ground vehicles and AI-supported targeting systems. These developments unfolded within a broader context of strategic rivalry, raising fears that autonomy could compress decision-making timelines in high-intensity conflicts and increase escalation risks.

By the early 2020s, more than ninety states had publicly expressed support for negotiating a legally binding framework to regulate or prohibit certain forms of autonomous weapons (UNODA, 2023). Yet divisions over definitions, particularly the meaning of “meaningful human control”, remained unresolved. Some states interpreted meaningful control as requiring direct human involvement in target selection and engagement decisions. Others viewed supervisory oversight or pre-programmed operational constraints as sufficient.

Thus, the evolution of the debate reveals a paradox. While normative concern has deepened and the number of states calling for regulation has grown, geopolitical competition and technological momentum have outpaced diplomatic consensus. The trajectory has moved from early ethical alarm to structured legal debate, from hypothetical risk to real-world deployment, and from exploratory dialogue to entrenched political division. The international community now faces a narrowing window in which regulatory frameworks might shape the development of autonomy, rather than attempt to contain it after widespread normalization.

Section

Current Situation

The Arms Race Without a Treaty

As of February 2026, the international community finds itself in a state of regulatory stagnation and technological acceleration. The diplomatic machinery addressing autonomous weapon systems has continued to operate under the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW), yet after more than a decade of deliberations, no legally binding instrument has emerged. The Group of Governmental Experts (GGE) reconvened throughout 2024 and 2025, and while states reaffirmed that International Humanitarian Law applies to all weapon systems, including those incorporating artificial intelligence, consensus on a treaty framework remains elusive (Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons, 2025).

By late 2025, over ninety states had publicly supported negotiating a legally binding instrument that would either prohibit or strictly regulate fully autonomous weapon systems (United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs, 2025). Austria, Brazil, Chile, Mexico, Costa Rica, and New Zealand have continued to advocate strongly for a prohibition framework, arguing that systems capable of selecting and engaging targets without meaningful human control pose unacceptable humanitarian risks. The African Group and the Non-Aligned Movement aligned with this position, emphasizing concerns about technological asymmetry and the risk of destabilizing proliferation.

However, key military powers remained divided. The United States maintains that existing International Humanitarian Law provides a sufficient framework for evaluating weapons legality through Article 36 weapons reviews, and continues to emphasize the concept of “appropriate human judgment” rather than endorsing a categorical prohibition (U.S. Department of Defense, 2023). Russia has reiterated its opposition to negotiating a binding ban within the CCW, arguing that autonomy enhances defensive capabilities and that premature restrictions could distort strategic balance. China’s position remains complex: while expressing support in principle for prohibiting fully autonomous lethal weapons, it has simultaneously advanced its doctrine of “intelligentized warfare,” integrating AI into command, surveillance, and targeting infrastructures. France and the United Kingdom have supported the concept of meaningful human control but have not endorsed a comprehensive ban.

The strategic environment has further complicated negotiations. The integration of artificial intelligence into military command systems has deepened major power rivalry. The United States has expanded operational testing of AI-enabled decision-support platforms under its Joint All-Domain Command and Control initiatives, designed to accelerate sensor-to-shooter timelines. China has publicly emphasized the role of AI in future high-intensity conflicts, embedding machine-learning systems into its military modernization agenda. Russia continues to test autonomous ground vehicles and loitering munitions with increasing levels of independent targeting functionality.

While no state has officially declared the deployment of a fully autonomous lethal system operating entirely without human oversight, the boundary between automated and autonomous systems has grown increasingly blurred. Loitering munitions with autonomous targeting capabilities have been used in multiple theaters since the early 2020s, and subsequent reporting has indicated incremental improvements in autonomy and swarm coordination technologies (United Nations Panel of Experts on Libya, 2021). Even when nominal human supervision is retained, operational realities raise questions about the extent to which meaningful control is exercised in fast-moving engagements.

Beyond interstate rivalry, concerns about proliferation have intensified. Advances in commercial artificial intelligence, open-source machine learning models, and dual-use drone technologies have lowered barriers to entry. Security analysts have warned that non-state actors may eventually gain access to semi-autonomous targeting systems assembled from commercially available components, complicating attribution and accountability mechanisms. In a global security environment already marked by proxy conflicts and asymmetric warfare, the diffusion of increasingly autonomous capabilities introduces additional instability.

Diplomatically, frustration has grown. In 2025, a coalition of states led by Austria and Brazil signaled openness to exploring negotiations outside the CCW framework if consensus remained blocked, invoking precedents such as the Ottawa Treaty on anti-personnel landmines. This possibility has introduced new tension into discussions, as major military powers resist processes that bypass consensus structures. Meanwhile, the United Nations Secretary-General has reiterated his call for a legally binding instrument prohibiting weapons systems that operate without meaningful human control, warning that the credibility of international humanitarian norms is at stake.

Thus, as of February 2026, the Security Council confronts a paradoxical landscape. Technological integration of AI into military systems is advancing steadily, normalization is occurring incrementally rather than dramatically, and yet the legal architecture governing lethal autonomy remains incomplete. The debate is no longer confined to abstract ethical speculation; it is embedded within broader patterns of great-power competition, technological rivalry, and the erosion of arms control regimes.

The Council must therefore consider not only whether autonomous weapon systems comply with existing International Humanitarian Law, but whether the current trajectory risks altering

the strategic calculus of conflict itself. In an era where algorithmic systems can process information and recommend, or execute, lethal decisions at machine speed, the margin for human deliberation narrows. The central question before this body is whether international peace and security can be preserved if the authority to apply lethal force increasingly migrates from human judgment to computational logic.

■ Political Context

The political landscape surrounding autonomous weapon systems is defined by fragmentation, strategic rivalry, and institutional paralysis. The issue sits at the intersection of emerging technology governance and great-power competition. While over ninety states have expressed support for negotiating a legally binding instrument regulating or prohibiting fully autonomous weapons (United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs, 2025), the states possessing the most advanced AI-enabled military capabilities remain cautious or resistant to binding constraints.

Within the Security Council, this division reflects broader tensions. The P5 members are not aligned on definitions of “meaningful human control”, nor on whether regulation should occur within the CCW or through an alternative treaty process. Smaller and middle powers have increasingly expressed frustration with the CCW’s consensus rule, which allows a small number of states to negotiate indefinitely. Discussions in 2025 about potentially pursuing an alternative treaty framework outside the CCW have introduced further diplomatic strain.

■ Economical Context

The economic dimension of autonomous weapon systems is inseparable from the global artificial intelligence industry. Military AI development is deeply intertwined with civilian innovation ecosystems. Companies that develop machine learning algorithms, computer vision systems, and robotics platforms for commercial purposes often operate within dual-use frameworks, meaning their technologies can be adapted for military application.

The global AI market has expanded rapidly over the past decade, with defense ministries in the United States, China, Israel, Russia, and several NATO member states allocating billions of dollars annually to AI research and development. The US Department of Defense’s AI initiatives under programs such as the Joint Artificial Intelligence Center and Joint All Domain Command and Control reflect sustained investment in decision support automation and battlefield integration. Similarly, China’s state driven AI strategy integrates military-civil fusion policies, blurring the boundary between private innovation and defense application.

At the same time, concerns about economic inequality between technologically advanced states and developing countries are intensifying. Many Global South states argue that autonomous weapons risk exacerbating military asymmetries, consolidating power among states with advanced AI infrastructures. The cost of developing, acquiring, and defending against such systems may widen existing security gaps, raising questions about equitable technological governance.

Therefore, the economic context is not simply about defense budgets. It is about the structural integration of AI into global markets and the financial incentives that drive military innovation forward faster than diplomatic regulation.

■ Social Context

Socially, the debate over autonomous weapons touches fundamentally anxieties about automation, control, and human agency. Public awareness of artificial intelligence has grown dramatically over the past decade, fueled by rapid advances in generative AI, automation in the workplace, and high-profile discussions about algorithmic bias. Within this broader societal shift, the idea of machines making life-and-death decisions provokes intense ethical concern. One of the most critical issues is the manifestation of social biases. These biases often reflect existing societal prejudices that are ingrained in the AI's training data or programming, leading to discriminatory targeting or dangerous outcomes on the battlefield. International disarmament forums, such as the Group of Governmental Experts, have emphasized the need for stakeholders to develop strategies that mitigate these biases that have been found to involve gender or appearance.

Civil society organizations, particularly the Campaign to Stop Killer Robots, have framed autonomous weapons as a moral red line. Their advocacy emphasizes the importance of maintaining human dignity and moral responsibility in warfare. Surveys conducted in multiple countries suggest widespread public discomfort with the concept of full autonomous lethal systems, even among populations that support strong national defense policies.

At the same time, public discourse is not uniform. In some states, particularly those experiencing ongoing security threats, narratives emphasizing technological superiority and force protection resonate strongly. Societies facing cross-border threats or insurgent violence may perceive autonomous systems as tools for precision and defensive efficiency rather than moral transgression.

Another social dimension concerns the risk of lowering the threshold for war. Critics argue that reducing the immediate human cost to deploying states could weaken domestic political constraints on the use of force. If casualties among one's own forces decrease, public opposition to military operations may diminish. This potential shift in the social contract between governments and citizens regarding war powers remains a deeply contested concern.

Section

Case Studies

■ Libyan Civil War (Kargu-2)

Autonomous Turkish Kargu-2 loitering munitions in 2020 Libyan civil war is widely referred to as a possible first battlefield use of lethal autonomous weapons. During Operation Peace Storm, Turkish-backed GNA (Government of National Accord) forces used various drones plus STM Kargu-2 loitering munitions against Haftar's LNA (Libyan National Army), including on logistics convoys and retreating units. UN experts reported that Kargu-2s were used in a fire/forget and find mode, able to search, select and attack targets without a live data link, describing it as a lethal autonomous weapon with machine learning based target recognition and swarming capability.

Some treat Libya as proof of concept that fully autonomous lethal engagement is now feasible and already fielded, others emphasize evidentiary uncertainty: open sources are thin, previous loitering munitions were already highly autonomous, and Libya may be more symbolic than technologically unique. Consequently, the Libya case is often treated as an important but inconclusive example rather than definitive proof of "killer robots" operating independently in combat.

Ethical legal analyses use Kargu-2 to highlight gaps in accountability, difficulties with distinction and proportionality, and arguments for bans or strict regulation of fully autonomous weapons. The Libyan Kargu-2 episode shows that AI enabled loitering munitions with significant autonomous functions are in real conflicts now, but whether they have already conducted indisputably unsupervised lethal attacks is still disputed.

The Libya case is particularly valuable for discussions on evidence and accountability. It demonstrates how difficult it can be to verify the actual level of autonomy used in combat operations and highlights the challenges of assigning legal responsibility when autonomous systems contribute to lethal decisions.

■ Nagorno-Karabakh

The 2020 Nagorno-Karabakh war is widely seen as a prototype of drone heavy warfare. The vast majority of the systems used were remotely operated drones and loitering munitions, but

some analyses classify these as early LAWS because of their growing autonomy. The conflict demonstrated how increasingly sophisticated drones and loitering munitions can transform military operations.

Azerbaijan massively employed Israeli loitering munitions and Turkish Bayraktar TB2 UCAVs, integrating them with artillery and ISR to destroy Armenian armor, artillery and air defences. These drones provided real-time targeting, “surgically precise” strikes, and psychological and propaganda effects via published strike videos. Analyses emphasize new tactics of mass UCAV raids to exhaust and then destroy air defence systems, enabling air superiority.

Global overviews of LAWS cite this case as evidence that highly autonomous UCAVs and loitering munitions are already normal on battlefields, blurring lines toward LAWS. Studies highlight the “democratization of air power”, relatively cheap, semi autonomous drones give smaller States disproportionate strike capability and challenge traditional air defence. Legal ethical work uses such conflicts to warn the increasing autonomy plus high speed threaten distinction, due care and escalation control.

In Nagorno-Karabakh, Azerbaijan relied on remotely operated UCAVs and loitering munitions with significant autonomy in navigation and engagement, but not clear, fully autonomous “killer robots”. The conflict is nonetheless central in arguments that LAWS like technologies are already reshaping warfare and accelerating the move toward more autonomous, harder to control lethal systems.

Nagorno-Karabakh is crucial for understanding the tactical impact of drones and semi-autonomous systems. It illustrates the “democratization of air power,” whereby relatively inexpensive technologies allow smaller states to achieve capabilities once reserved for major military powers. The case also shows how autonomous functions can enhance battlefield effectiveness even without fully autonomous lethal decision making.

■ Russia-Ukraine

The Russian-Ukraine war is the most intensively drone saturated conflict to date. Most systems are remotely operated with growing autonomy, rather than fully human out of the loop, lethal autonomous weapon systems.

Both sides employ a wide spectrum of UCAVs and robotic systems for reconnaissance, strike, EW, logistics, and air defence, with increasing decision making autonomy and swarm concepts. Russia heavily uses shahed-type loitering munitions and diverse FPV kamikaze drones; Ukraine fields mass FPV fleets, long range strike drones, and AI assisted interceptor and detection systems. Some analyses describe a trend toward AI driven targeting and computer vision, enabling more autonomous navigation, recognition, and engagement in dense EW environments.

Surveys of current LAWS note Ukraine among battlefields where loitering munitions and UCAVs blur into LAWS, but still emphasize continuing human supervision in critical functions. Legal analyses describe Ukraine's current unmanned systems as transitional technology toward fully autonomous systems, predicting their appearance in the near future rather than documenting routine use now. Multiple papers argue that drone/LAWS use in Ukraine strains distinction, proportionality, and accountability, with evidence of indiscriminate or civilian harming attacks requiring investigation.

The Ukraine war showcases massive, innovative use of drones and robotic systems with increasing autonomy in navigation, sensing and targeting assistance, but most lethal decisions still involve a human. The conflict is therefore seen less as full deployment of LAWS and more as a major stepping stone towards them, raising urgent legal and ethical questions.

Ukraine highlights the phenomenon of incremental autonomy rather than fully autonomous warfare. The conflict demonstrates how AI assisted targeting, electronic warfare, FPV drones, and autonomous navigation are gradually changing military operations. It also shows how technological competition can accelerate the adoption of increasingly autonomous systems, raising concerns about escalation, accountability, and the future role of human control in warfare.

Section

Past International Actions

Between Alarm and Action

International engagement on autonomous weapon systems did not begin with treaty negotiations, but with growing institutional recognition that emerging technologies were beginning to outpace normative regulation. The first structured multilateral action occurred within the framework of the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW), where states agreed to begin informal discussions on what were then referred to as “lethal autonomous weapon systems”. By 2014, States Parties formally established a Group of Government Experts (GGE) to examine the technological, legal, ethical, and military dimensions of autonomy in weapons systems (Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons, 2014). This marked the first sustained international effort to address the issue through a dedicated institutional mechanism.

From 2014 onward, the GGE convened annually, gradually moving from conceptual exploration toward normative clarification. Early sessions focused on definitional challenges, particularly whether autonomy should be assessed in terms of technical capability or in terms of the degree of human control exercised in targeting and engagement decisions. Over time, participating states reaffirmed that International Humanitarian Law applies to all weapons systems, including those incorporating artificial intelligence (Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons, 2019). However, despite repeated affirmations of IHL applicability, the GGE stopped short of recommending a binding instrument. The consensus based decision making structure of the CCW allowed dissenting states to prevent movement toward negotiations on prohibition or regulation, even as a growing number of states expressed support for such measures.

Parallel to these diplomatic processes, The United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs (UNODA) elevated the issue within broader discussions of emerging technologies and international peace and security. UNODA reports consistently emphasized that while autonomous systems are not explicitly prohibited under existing treaties, their development raises serious concerns regarding compliance with principles of distinction, proportionality, and accountability (United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs, 2019). By framing the issue as one of legal sufficiency rather than mere technical innovation, UNODA contributed to shifting the debate from whether autonomy was possible to whether it was governable under current law.

By the early 2020s, frustration with the slow pace of progress within the CCW framework led several states to seek alternative avenues. In December 2024, the United Nations General Assembly adopted a resolution on lethal autonomous weapon systems with overwhelming support, signaling broad political momentum for advancing negotiations toward a legally binding instrument (United Nations General Assembly, 2024). While General Assembly resolutions are not legally binding, the vote reflected increasing dissatisfaction with procedural stagnation and demonstrated that the majority of UN Member States supported stronger regulatory efforts.

This momentum continued into 2025, when subsequent General Assembly action reaffirmed the need for continued deliberation and consideration of legally binding measures (United Nations General Assembly, 2025). These resolutions underscored the widening gap between the technological trajectory of autonomy and the pace of legal codification. They also reflected growing alignment among states in Latin America, Africa, and parts of Europe advocating for clearer constraints on systems capable of selecting and engaging targets without meaningful human oversight.

In parallel, the International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC) issued a comprehensive position paper in 2021 calling for new legally binding rules to ensure human control over the use of force and to prohibit unpredictable autonomous weapon systems (International Committee of the Red Cross, 2021). The ICRC's intervention carried particular weight due to its institutional role as a guardian of International Humanitarian Law. By arguing that autonomous systems could create unacceptable risks of IHL violations, the ICRC shifted the debate from abstract ethical concern to operational legal compliance.

Section

Bloc Positions

■ Technological Powers

One bloc within the Council consists of states that possess highly developed artificial intelligence ecosystems and deeply integrated defense-industrial infrastructures. For these actors, autonomy in weapons systems is not a hypothetical policy dilemma but a practical dimension of military modernization. Their strategic calculus prioritizes maintaining technological superiority, reducing risks to personnel, and enhancing precision in complex operational environments.

These states tend to argue that existing International Humanitarian Law is technologically neutral and therefore fully applicable to autonomous systems. From their perspective, the legal issue is not whether autonomy is permissible, but whether proper national weapons reviews, processes and command structures ensure compliance. They resist categorical prohibitions, viewing them as premature and potentially destabilizing. Instead, they favor regulatory language centered on “meaningful human involvement”, «appropriate oversight”, and accountability mechanisms that preserve operational flexibility.

This bloc is unlikely to support sweeping bans or intrusive verification mechanisms. However, it may support transparency measures, best-practice exchanges, or political commitments reaffirming the continued applicability of IHL. Their position is shaped not by humanitarian indifference, but by a belief that strategic advantage and legal compliance can coexist within a controlled autonomy framework.

■ Strategic Autonomy and Sovereignty

Another bloc approaches the issue primarily through the lens of geopolitical rivalry and strategic equilibrium. For these actors, autonomous systems represent a tool within broader deterrence architectures and technological competition. Their central concern is that premature or asymmetrical regulation could constrain their capabilities relative to rival powers.

This bloc emphasizes sovereign equality and frequently resists legally binding instruments negotiated under pressure from technologically dominant states. It tends to frame autonomy as an inevitable evolution in military affairs and argues that international law should adapt incre-

mentally rather than through categorical prohibition. Skepticism toward external verification regimes and intrusive oversight is particularly strong within this grouping.

While these states may engage constructively in definitional debates and affirm the applicability of IHL, they are unlikely to support binding prohibitions unless confident that such measures apply universally and verifiably. Their position reflects a prioritization of strategic balance and long term technological autonomy over immediate normative codification.

■ Regulatory Middle Powers

Consists of states that do not sit at the forefront of military AI development but maintain strong commitments to multilateral governance, arms control traditions, and humanitarian law frameworks. These actors often see autonomous weapon systems as emblematic of a broader governance gap between technological innovation and legal adaptation.

Their approach typically supports codifying the concept of meaningful human control in clearer, possibly binding terms. They may not always demand a full prohibition, but they advocate structured constraints to prevent the delegation of life and death decisions entirely to machines. Transparency, reporting obligations, and international dialogue mechanisms are seen as tools to mitigate destabilizing risks.

This bloc often positions itself as a bridge between technologically advanced powers and prohibition advocates. It may push for regulatory compromise formulas that preserve defensive innovation while preventing systems that operate without human decision making input. In negotiations, these states are potential consensus-builders.

■ Global South Pro-Regulation

This bloc approaches autonomous weapon systems through the lens of humanitarian protection, structural inequality, and precaution. States within this current are generally not leading developers of advanced military AI and therefore assess autonomy less as a tool of modernization and more as potential source of instability. Their concern centers on the delegation of lethal decision making-algorithms in a system already marked by uneven technological capacity and weak accountability mechanisms in conflict settings.

For these actors, the primary risk lies in normalization. They argue that once fully autonomous systems become operationally embedded, regulatory internationalization will become significantly more difficult. As a result, they advocate early codification of clear limits, particularly the legal definition and preservation of meaningful human control over targeting decisions. Many within this bloc support negotiating a legally binding instrument that would prohibit systems operating without direct human involvement in the use of lethal force.

This position is also shaped by concerns about proliferation. The dual use nature of artificial intelligence and drone technologies raises fears that increasingly lethal autonomous systems could diffuse into fragile or conflict prone regions, exacerbating instability and complicating attribution. From this perspective, regulation is not anti-technology, it's a preventive safeguard against widening global military asymmetries.

■ Security Sensitive Balancers

This bloc approaches lethal autonomous weapon systems primarily through the lens of immediate regional security dynamics. States within this grouping operate in environments shaped by active strategic rivalries and deterrence considerations. As a result, they are cautious about endorsing sweeping prohibitions that could be perceived as constraining their ability to maintain strategic balance relative to neighboring competitors. For them, autonomy is not simply a normative dilemma, it's a variable within existing deterrence equations.

At the same time, these actors have a record of engaging constructively in multilateral arms control discussions. They may support clearer definitions, regulatory frameworks, and reaffirmations of International Humanitarian Law, provided that such measures do not undermine their security posture. Their position is therefore calibrated rather than ideological, seeking regulatory clarity while preserving strategic flexibility.

Section

Previous Documents

Delegates must submit a **position paper** and an **opening speech**. Both documents must be sent to the Dais email address by the deadline indicated below:

■ **Submission deadline: August 11 before midnight (11:59 p.m.)**

Section

Qarmas

1. How should the Security Council define “meaningful human control” in a way that is operationally measurable rather than politically ambiguous?
2. What specific level of autonomy (in the loop, on the loop, out of the loop) should be considered legally acceptable under international law?
3. How can principles like distinction and proportionality be meaningfully applied to algorithmic decision making systems?
4. Who bears legal responsibility when an autonomous system commits a violation: the programmer, the commander, the manufacturer, or the State?
5. How can the UNSC address the risks of an AI arms race among major powers?
6. What measures can be implemented to prevent the proliferation of semi or fully autonomous weapons to nonstate actors?
7. How can a regulatory framework balance humanitarian concerns with the security interests of technologically advanced states?
8. Should the definition of Lethal Autonomous Weapon Systems (LAWS) be capability based, function based, or intent based and what are the consequences of each approach?
9. How can the Security Council prevent the emergence of an “accountability gap” in autonomous warfare?
10. What role should subsidiary bodies or panels of experts play in monitoring LAWS development and deployment?
11. Should there be export controls or international licensing systems for AI-enabled military technologies?

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12. How can the Council address the accessibility of dual-use commercial AI and drone technologies?

Section

Committee Assignments

■ Permanent members

1. People's Republic of China
2. French Republic
3. Russian Federation
4. United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland
5. United States of America

■ Non-permanent members

1. Kingdom of Denmark
2. Hellenic Republic (Greece)
3. Islamic Republic of Pakistan
4. Republic of Panama
5. Federal Republic of Somalia
6. Kingdom of Bahrain
7. Republic of Colombia
8. Republic of Latvia
9. Republic of Liberia
10. Democratic Republic of the Congo

■ Extras / non members invited to the discussion (No vote)

1. Republic of Austria - Prominent role in advocating for stronger international regulation of autonomous weapons systems within multilateral forums.
2. Federative Republic of Brazil - Prominent role in advocating for stronger international regulation of autonomous weapons systems within multilateral forums.
3. Republic of Ecuador - Provide important perspectives from Latin America, a region that has generally supported stronger humanitarian regulation of emerging weapons technologies.

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4. Republic of El Salvador - Provide important perspectives from Latin America, a region that has generally supported stronger humanitarian regulation of emerging weapons technologies.
 5. Republic of India - Significant actor in the development, production, or strategic use of advanced military technologies, artificial intelligence, and unmanned systems.
 6. State of Israel - Significant actor in the development, production, or strategic use of advanced military technologies, artificial intelligence, and unmanned systems.
 7. Japan - Significant actor in the development, production, or strategic use of advanced military technologies, artificial intelligence, and unmanned systems.
 8. Republic of Mali - Experience with armed conflict, peacekeeping operations, and security challenges that raise important questions regarding the future use of autonomous systems in conflict environments.
 9. Republic of the Sudan - Experience with armed conflict, peacekeeping operations, and security challenges that raise important questions regarding the future use of autonomous systems in conflict environments.
 10. Republic of Türkiye - Significant actor in the development, production, or strategic use of advanced military technologies, artificial intelligence, and unmanned systems.

Section

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